

I STAR TO STAR FACTORY

From a cottage industry revolving around one star, Bollywood became a multi-starrer big bucks business

Cinema has always been a unifying medium for this diverse country, an obsession with its masses who have held their film stars in awe, emulated their ways of dressing and even speaking. In May 1980, INDIA TODAY reduced Bollywood to a "one-man factory," that was Amitabh Bachchan. "Each time he leaves his elegant house in Bombay's Juhu-Ville Parle scheme, investments worth Rs 50 crore ride on him. So much in demand is the dark, taciturn star that the hordes of eager producers who queue up outside his dressing rooms are told that they cannot expect shooting dates before early 1983,"

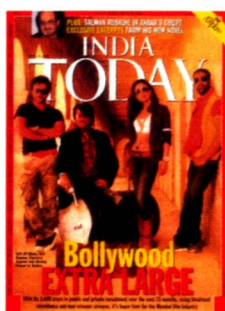
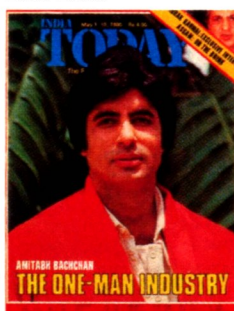
said the article. It was said that "Bachchan is a cult above the rest." But today, the scene has changed. Everyone's speaking a new language. There is a new economy of Bollywood and it's extra large. "From corporates in Hugo Boss suits to independent producers in Gucci T-shirts, there's a new buzz in town," said INDIA TODAY in April 2008. "Bollywood launches a new consumer product every Friday with one-tenth of FMCG budgets. And every Friday, the product gets bigger." With the arrival of fresh-faced yuppies, Bollywood has become a money-making factory, where everyone with big bucks, is welcome.

“This man is not just a star. Amitabh Bachchan is an industry.”

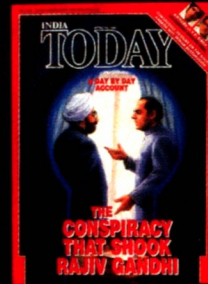
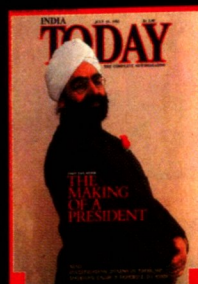
ALAIN CHAMAS

A FRENCH PRODUCER WHO TRIED TO SIGN HIM FOR HIS FILM, 1980

1980-2008



1982-1988



MATE TO CHECKMATE

A President who went from devotee to dissenter

As the countdown to the presidential election reached its final stages last fortnight, there was only a disquieting awareness of the creeping gap between appearances and reality; a growing feeling that the very dignity of the office was in danger," said INDIA TODAY in July 1982. From a loyalist of the Nehru clan to his split with Rajiv Gandhi, Giani Zail Singh was a different man when he started on his journey to become the first Sikh President of the country, only to be later known as a "President who revelled in playing politics" (INDIA TODAY, April 1988). "If my leader had said I should pick up a broom and be a sweeper, I would have done that. She chose me to be President," Singh was quoted as saying in 1982. "It was, an all too tragic confirmation that far from being above it, the Presidency has merely been reduced to just another pawn in the perennial political power game, perhaps more important than the pawn but potently less than the queen," observed INDIA TODAY in 1982. Things were just waiting to happen. "After making an almost inadvertent but scandalous statement about Rs 30 crore to Rs 40 crore being offered to him to stand for re-election, and then putting his foot in his mouth repeatedly in the effort to extricate himself from the controversy, Zail Singh has done himself little good," said the magazine in 1988. Zail Singh descended to plotting when he should have been above such battles. And all the while, he underestimated Rajiv Gandhi's own deceptively hidden ability to play the same game.

“Rajiv Gandhi has entered politics but has not learnt politics.”

GIANI ZAIL SINGH

FORMER PRESIDENT OF INDIA, 1988